

Improving longevity is key

Whether age is a number or a word, top sportspeople are better **aware** of their bodies.

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When someone says “age is only a number,” you can be sure they are not in their twenties. Young people have no need for such consolation.

The received wisdom is that achievers in all fields are getting younger, an argument buttressed by the fact that Malala Yousufzai won the Nobel Prize at 17. It is easier to find young achievers in sport. The youngest participant in the Tokyo Olympics was Syrian Hand Zaza, 12, in table tennis. At the other end of the scale was the Australian Mary Hanna, who took part in the equestrian events at 66. Compatriot Andrew Hoy was 62 and in his eighth Olympics in the same event. Roger Federer played his last competitive tennis match at 41. But these are the outliers.

We age, we slow down, and we try to make up for the physical decline by using experience and game-cleverness as substitutes in sports. The surgeon and Alpine climber George Wherry put it best. He said, “After 40, a climber is in the old age of his youth and must not be reckless as to pace; his endurance and sure-footedness may be better, but his elasticity is less so.” What you gain on the roundabouts, you lose on the swings.

Research on sport and ageing is interesting. According to a report published by the ARC Centre of Excellence in Population Ageing Research, since 1992, the average age of Olympians has gone up from 25 to 27. We are



Keeping fit: Roger Federer played his last competitive tennis match at the age of 41. AFP

competing better at a later (even if only slightly later) age. As all sportspeople tell themselves, it ain't over till it's over!

We live longer for much the same reason that we compete for longer. Naturally, there is a connection. In the latter case, improvements in medicine and sports science, innovations in equipment (those shoes!), and better organised training have all contributed to its longevity.

The average age of the top 100 tennis players has gone up from 26 to 28. Among women, it is now 26, compared to 24 three decades ago. The study states: “This may be attributed to a continued shift in racquet technology and game style. For example, tennis play has largely moved away from the explosive athleticism of a serve-and-volley strategy. Instead, the backcourt style has become popular, putting more emphasis on power that can be generated from better racquets and endurance, a domain of older athletes.”

In chess, where Viswanathan Anand remains in the top 10 at the age of 54, a study of 24,000 games showed that players were at their best at about 40. Magnus Carlsen, the No. 1 player, is still only 33; it is up to him to keep his interest in the game alive!

Whether age is a number or a word, top sportspeople are better aware of their bodies. Governing bodies, too, are beginning to understand the need for rest, and rather than levying fines for missing tournaments, they often encourage early or mid-career breaks, thus improving longevity. Age is money, too.